



OFFICE OF THE MAYOR

Sumbul Siddiqui
Mayor (2020-21, 2022-23, 2026-27)

To: Cambridge City Council
From: Sumbul Siddiqui, Mayor
Date: July 29, 2026
Subject: Communicating Information from the School Committee

To the Honorable, the City Council:

I write to provide an updated summary of recent Cambridge School Committee activity.

Summer School Committee Meeting

The School Committee is currently on recess but will convene for the August 4 summer meeting. At this meeting, the Superintendent will present various matters pertaining to the opening of the 2026-27 school year, including follow up reports from last school year. This will include brief updates on:

- Secondary math instruction, including Algebra course offerings to 8th and 9th grade students;
- Developing guidance around appropriate use of technology and monitoring of screen time by students;
- Specific efforts to prioritize literacy instruction across elementary grade levels;
- And upcoming public engagement and deliberations over the future use of 158 Spring Street.

Additionally, the Superintendent and Chief Academic Officer will be joined by representatives of Attuned Education Partners LLC to provide an update on the ongoing development of the long-term strategic plan for the Cambridge Public Schools. The last update was provided at the [June 16](#) school committee meeting in which they shared the first draft of 10-year aspirations and aligned experiences, an overview of the organizational diagnostic process, and strengths and challenges surfaced across CPS. At the August 4 meeting, the School Committee will receive updates on the refined aspirations developed in response to leadership and School Committee feedback, refined aspirations based on leadership and School Committee feedback, a revised draft of the aspirations and mission measures, and a draft of the strategic priorities and initiatives for the next CPS strategic plan.

Contract Negotiations

Contract negotiations are ongoing with the Cambridge Education Association (CEA), who represent our teachers, administrators, clerical workers, building substitutes and paraprofessionals. The School



Committee continues to negotiate in good faith, while proposing significant investments in compensation and benefits that would help the Cambridge Public Schools continue to maintain an exceptional workforce. The following is a condensed list of proposals and agreements, with a more [comprehensive summary available here](#):

- The School Committee proposed a redesigned paraprofessional wage scale to increase base compensation of our lowest paid paraprofessionals by nearly 60% over the next two years equaling the most competitive paraprofessional salary schedules in Massachusetts, an increase for which the CEA has publicly advocated.
- The School Committee has further agreed to extend parental leave for all full-time CEA members to 12 weeks.
- The School Committee has also proposed modest reforms to the school calendar and reallocations of time devoted to family engagement efforts to better serve our students.
- These proposals are in addition to competitive wage increases for all employees, enhanced tuition reimbursements and increased classroom stipends, all of which are aimed to improve working conditions for all employees.

Current proposals by CEA would require an estimated 18% increase to the CPS operating budget in the first year of implementation with those costs increasing in subsequent years. This would represent a budget increase more than three times greater than our yearly increase and require at least an additional \$175 million over the next three years. As previously communicated by the Superintendent, these proposals well exceed the district's financial or operational capacity, but they remain hopeful that these contracts can be finalized before the new school year begins.

Upcoming Dates

CPS Community Fairs

In partnership with CPS, the Mayor's Office is organizing the 2026 Community Fairs! My office first started these fairs during my second term, and they are a great opportunity for families to meet community partners, learn about community services, and access free supplies, resources, and clothing. The CPS Community Fairs will be Saturday, August 29 at 10 a.m. outside King Open School and September 12 at 10 a.m. outside Peabody School.

2026-27 School Year Calendar

When Labor Day falls after September 5, the first day of school for students is the Tuesday before Labor Day. Therefore, this year, the first day of school is *Tuesday, September 1, 2026*. A more detailed and printable 2026-27 CPS District Calendar is available [here](#).



Please do not hesitate to reach out with any questions or requests for additional information. Our summer meeting will be August 4, 2026, with regular School Committee meetings starting again September 1, 2026.

Sincerely,

Sumbul Siddiqui
Mayor of Cambridge (2020-21, 2022-23, 2026-27)